Man on Decades-Long Journey to Helping Others

Tim Gibney of Woodstock, Ontario, interviewed dozens of people with uplifting stories before launching a series of seminars aimed at boosting others.
Tim Gibney has been on a mission of sorts that started 20 years ago. The Woodstock, Ontario man listened to what his daughters – Charlotte, in Grade 8 at the time, and Nicole, then a Grade 2 student – were saying about what their classmates were going through in their school studies back in 1992. “How are these young people learning with what’s going on in their lives?” he asked in a question posed in an Aug. 5 interview. There were trying times for the students he was hearing about, between home, their peers, and other people in their lives. It was from that starting point that Gibney began to seek out people with inspirational stories, who had overcome trying times in their lives. Source: Write My Paper online magazine.

Lifting the Spirit

That year, Gibney sought out the mayor of Woodstock – at that time, John Geoghegan – and asked for people in the community who had stories to tell. “If anybody knew about unique and interesting people,” he said," the mayor was a likely person to help get contacts." The first one in line was the now-late Ed Bennett, a veteran of the Second World War who lost an eye in the Allied raid on Dieppe and was then a prisoner of war.

From there, Gibney went to other people in Woodstock and beyond, listening intently to what they had to say about their lives. These interviews went on for several years and included talks with about 40 to 50 people. They included a woman from London, Ontario who lost her vision at age eight – “that’s got to throw people for a loop,” Gibney said – but she endured her hardship well. There was also a woman who suffered a variety of abuses. That woman left an abusive relationship and, after a stint on welfare, received a national award a few years later that recognized her savvy in business. In addition, a man who suffered a debilitating illness that essentially fused his joints as it ravaged his body was on the list. The man's illness basically left him a paraplegic, but it didn’t destroy his spirit.

Sharing Through Seminars

A few years ago, Gibney started giving free seminars entitled Breaking Free and Stepping Up, based largely on his interviews. The seminars looked at how people overcame their challenges and could better themselves. Gibney likened himself to a coach in the seminar presentations, which looks at people's objectives, beliefs, their ability to trust, benefit, adapt, have pleasure, approach their problems, and endure. "It's so that people who have had challenges can see value in their (situations)," Gibney concluded.

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